

Chapter 1

The clashing of steel and the agonized cries of fallen knights echoed through the night as Lancelot urged his horse through the chaos engulfing Camelot. Smoke billowed from burning towers, casting an eerie glow over the crumbling walls. Behind him, Guinevere clung tightly, her golden hair whipping wildly in the turbulent wind as they fled the destruction. Lancelot could feel her trembling against his back - no doubt still shaken from her narrow escape from the fiery pyre where she had been moments away from meeting her end.

Lancelot glanced down at the sword in his hand, though he had only used it in this battle, it was now broken and useless. 'Lady Cailin was right,' he thought bitterly, 'Excalibur *is* Fang, and I had her in my hands! That pile of shit will pay!' The weight of his failure gnawed at him, fueling his determination to reclaim what was rightfully his.

As they cleared the city gates, a sudden twang pierced the air, like the snap of a well-drawn bow. Lancelot's eyes widened as he turned and watched the arrow speed towards them, a deadly dart of polished wood and sharpened steel. In a desperate bid to shield Guinevere, he tried to twist the horse, but the projectile found its mark, grazing her shoulder. Guinevere let out a pained cry, her grip momentarily slipping before she regained her hold on him, her knuckles turning white as she gripped his cloak.

The horse thundered onward, its hooves pounding against the dirt path as they fled into the darkened forest. Lancelot risked a glance back, catching a glimpse of a familiar figure silhouetted against the flickering flames on the battlements - Arthur, his face twisted in a cruel grin, a dark promise of vengeance etched upon his features.

'So, the fool thinks he's won,' Lancelot growled inwardly, his knuckles whitening around the sword's hilt. 'But I will have my vengeance, and Fang will be mine once more.'

As the miles stretched on, Lancelot felt Guinevere's grip begin to weaken, her body swaying precariously atop the horse. Alarm flooded him - the wound must have been more serious than he'd thought.

Lancelot guided the horse off the path and into a small clearing, determined to get Guinevere the care she so desperately needed. But the moment he brought the steed to a halt, her hold suddenly failed, and she began to slip from the saddle.

Lancelot moved with supernatural speed, his body a blur as he caught her lithe form before it could hit the hard-packed earth.

"Adel?" he murmured, using the name he had known her by for centuries. His voice was tinged with a rare note of worry as he gazed upon her pallid features, her skin now ashen and drawn.

Adel's eyes fluttered open, the once-vibrant emerald hues now fading like a guttering candle in the wind. "Jack," she whispered, speaking Lancelot's true name, her voice barely audible, barely a breath upon the night air. "You may have taken me from Camelot, but Zahilla has won. Now he has Fang, and he has me."

Jack's blood ran cold at her words, a surge of primal rage coursing through him like wildfire. Zahilla, or as his subjects in this lifetime knew him, King Arthur, had indeed succeeded. As Guinevere breathed her last breath, Adel's soul went back to the triple spiral symbol on Fang's grip. Once more, Zahilla had killed her, and once more he believed he had won. Jack could tell that this was the time for vengeance, this was the time for war. The gods' sick, twisted game had begun anew.

Two months prior:

As Lancelot approached the chamber, his gaze was drawn to the legendary sword, Excalibur, which rested at the center of the round table. He was driven by a deep desire to reclaim his rightful sword, and his unshakable loyalty to Lady Cailin in regard to what she had told him not so long ago.

However, as he reached out to grasp Excalibur, Lancelot noticed a swirling dust of green and purple enveloping the sword. He recognized this as no ordinary phenomenon - it was nexus-dust, a strange material that appeared liquid yet crumbled like powder. This "dust" was visible only to beings like himself, and its presence suggested that something was profoundly amiss, perhaps a trap set by a god.

Yet, Lancelot remained undeterred. He was driven by the memory of Lady Cailin's last command to him. On that day, Lancelot had approached the wise woman at her castle, his brow furrowed with frustration. "My lady," he had said, bowing low, "I fear I am useless as a knight in your service. Every weapon I wield seems to break in my hands. How can I in good conscience protect you when my weapons fail me?"

Lady Cailin regarded him with a knowing smile. "Lancelot, you are named so because every sword you pick up with the intent to kill has broken in your hands. But your true sword, the one that will not fail you, sits at the round table in Camelot. You must go there and reclaim her."

With those encouraging words now fresh in his mind, Lancelot reached out and grasped Excalibur. "Fang, you have been waiting for me for 400 years. I am here now," he declared.

But as Lancelot went to raise Fang in triumph, he found himself frozen, unable to move. The green and purple dust now enveloped him as well. As it did so the round table reshaped into a rectangle, with Fang pointing directly at Arthur's occupied chair at the head of the table.

King Arthur was not the man in the chair, however, and Lancelot did not recognize him. Rather than the pompous ruler who hid his hubris from his people, there sat an older man with a long white beard, flowing robes, and a wizened countenance. Upon further study Lancelot realized that the man seated before him was no mortal, but a god-like being, similar to Lancelot himself.

"Lancelot! Your Jack?! Oh, if Zahilla realized who you are! This Æon is actually going to be good. I mean Æon 1 wasn't bad, and it was brutal what Talroc did to you. But... well, the final battle was great, but the rest was just not 'god of destruction' kind of material," Merlin exclaimed, his words spilling out excitedly.

Jack growled, frustrated that this no name god had trapped him. "Arthur told me that he had the help of a wizard named Merlin. He should have just come out and said you're a wannabe god. Pft... Is Merlin your celestial name, or did you make that one up?"

Merlin smiled but did not move. Jack realized they were both frozen in place. "Well, at least the name I picked isn't predated 2 thousand years... really, I do not know how the Odyssey let you get away with that. You would think it would cause dust every time anyone from, I don't know, Æon 0 on up to 3 were to use it. Speaking of 0, is it true that they made you endure Æon 0 for a thousand years?"

Jack did not see the need to answer Merlin's question. Instead, he thought over what Merlin had said and waited with growing frustration for Merlin's sub- Æon to end. By Merlin's own words, he had confirmed to him that Zahilla is Arthur. Which meant for certainty that Guinevere is Adel. As his hand had come down on Fang's, Jack had noticed the green color in her triple spiral symbol. *That must be Blain.* He thought.

While he considered this, Jack noticed that some of the green and purple nexus-dust had snaked its way up his arm and was now swirling about his head and into his nose. As it reached his throat, his defiant thoughts escaped him, and he was compelled to answer Merlin. "No, Æon 0 ended at 900 years," he said flatly, wishing for enough movement so that he could cut out his own tongue.

"900 years! That's impressive. Methuselah made it like, I think he resisted for 969 years but he was going for a record, not a punishment. Man! I mean, I know the thing with Danielle was really bad, but I don't think anyone should be forced to endure for any longer than... what's the average? 500 years, I think."

At the mention of the name Danielle Jack's rage built. Here was a name that Jack held sacred and should never fall out of anyone's mouth so carelessly, especially around him. Perhaps it was just the end of the sub-Æon, or maybe this burst of anger was powerful enough to break Merlin's creation. Either way, Jack felt his arm begin to twitch, his fingers curling tighter around Fang's grip. He imagined the punishments he would exact on Arthur for Merlin's insolence, and with that, he felt his feet release and his muscles tighten, ready to move before Merlin expected it.

"Listen, this thing is almost done, but we'll talk again," Merlin added, noting Jack's subtle movements.

The room then completely filled with dust until Jack could no longer see. "FANG!" he shouted, mentally projecting to ensure she knew he was there. But the feeling of her grip faded, and when the green and purple cloud cleared, the table was round once more, and Merlin and Fang were nowhere to be seen.

Just then, he heard the soft patter of footsteps approaching, and Guinevere emerged from the shadows, her brow creased with concern. "Lancelot, what is the matter? I heard your shout from the courtyard."

Lancelot forced a reassuring smile, covering his earlier outburst. "Forgive me, my lady. I... I thought I had lost something important to me. But it seems I was mistaken."

Guinevere drew closer, her emerald eyes searching his face. "You seem troubled. Is there aught I can do to ease your mind?" There was a hint of warmth in her voice, an almost maternal compassion that tugged at the heartstrings Lancelot had long tried to keep buried.

He swallowed hard, struggling to maintain his composure. The way Guinevere looked at him, with such genuine care and concern, stirred memories of another woman. Lost to him long ago. "It is nothing, my lady. I was merely... distracted." He risked a glance at her, seeing the worry etched upon her delicate features.

Guinevere reached out, placing a gentle hand on his arm. "Lancelot, you have always been a true friend and loyal knight. If there is a burden weighing on your heart, please, let me share it." Her touch sent a strange current of emotion through him and instinctively he closed his eyes. In his mind's eye the woman standing before him was not Guinevere or Adel, but rather the fiery red head woman from long ago, Danielle.

But he knew that he would have to open his eyes and face reality. This was merely Adel's mortal form, not the woman he had once loved. Danielle was gone, lost to him forever, and no one could ever replace her. "Stop it, Jack," he chided himself internally. "Adel is not Danielle. No one can ever be her."

"I appreciate your concern, my lady," he said, his voice steady. "But I assure you, it is nothing that requires your attention. I merely lost my train of thought for a moment." He offered her a reassuring smile, hoping to put an end to this unwanted display of affection.

Guinevere studied him for a long moment, her lips pursed thoughtfully. Then, with a slight nod, she withdrew her hand. "Very well, Lancelot. But know that if you ever wish to unburden your heart, I am here to listen."

As she turned to leave, Lancelot watched Guinevere go, his jaw clenched tight. He had to be careful – he knew it would be easy for him to forget about everything and just let the souls die as they will. Jack mused with the idea of running away and letting Adel forget. *After all*, Jack thought, *she has already made her mistake again. Can she learn?*

But, as Merlin had suggested, time was pain to Jack and the more time he wasted, the longer he would have to endure. His focus had to remain on reclaiming Fang and stopping Zahilla, no matter the cost. Jack told himself that Adel could still have a chance, but part of him knew this was a folly. He decided in the end that he should try to keep his distance from her and not allow them to be alone like this again.

With a resigned sigh, Lancelot turned and strode from the chamber, his steps purposeful. The road ahead would be arduous, but he had no choice but to forge on. Zahilla would pay dearly for his transgressions, and Jack would not rest until he had reclaimed what was rightfully his - both Fang and the chance to guide Adel down the proper path.

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As he made his way through the winding corridors of Camelot, Lancelot's thoughts drifted to the other knights who would prove crucial in the battles to come. Among them was Sir Palamedes, whose headstrong nature and growing disillusionment with Arthur's rule would make him a valuable, if unpredictable, ally.

Lancelot's brow furrowed as he rounded a corner and nearly collided with the very knight he had been thinking of. Palamedes' keen eyes narrowed, catching the troubled expression on Lancelot's face.

"Lancelot," Palamedes said, his voice tinged with curiosity. "I heard a shout coming from the throne room. That was you, was it not?"

"It was nothing," Lancelot replied, his tone clipped. The last thing he needed was for Palamedes to start asking questions he couldn't, or wouldn't, answer.

Palamedes studied him for a long moment, his expression unreadable. Then, with a slight nod, he stepped aside. "Very well. But know that if you have need of an ally, I'm here."

"Lancelot!" came a voice from behind them, sharp and accusatory. Lancelot turned to see Sir Agravain striding towards them, his brow furrowed in a scowl.

"Ah, Agravain," Palamedes said, his tone laced with a hint of disdain. "I should have known you'd be lurking about, ready to stick your nose where it doesn't belong."

Agravain ignored Palamedes and narrowed eyes at Lancelot. "I heard the commotion from the throne room. What is the meaning of this? Has our illustrious champion fallen out of favor with the king?"

Inwardly, Jack found himself intrigued by Agravain's blunt, almost malicious demeanor. There was a certain ruthless pragmatism to the knight that Jack couldn't help but admire, even as Lancelot maintained a neutral expression.

"It was nothing," Lancelot repeated, his voice calm and measured. "I merely had a moment of... distraction. Nothing more."

Agravain scoffed, unconvinced. "Distraction, hmm? Well, we can ill afford such lapses, a spy might see such an outburst and think you have gone mad."

Palamedes' brow furrowed for a moment but then turned to a look of excitement. "Oh, have you heard the rumors? They say Merlin has returned to Camelot, and that he knows the location of the Grail."

Agravain scoffed, his contempt for the old wizard evident. "Merlin? That old fool? If he has indeed returned, then the Grail is as good as lost. There are not enough men pure of heart in this land for such a sacred relic to coexist in any dwelling."

Jack couldn't help but agree with Agravain's assessment, even as Lancelot maintained his composure. The knights of Camelot were a flawed and weathered bunch, their honor often tarnished by the demands of court politics and the brutality of warfare. The idea of one of them being worthy of the Grail seemed laughable.

Jack knew that their leader, the great and holy King Arthur, was the worst of them all. Arthur was no holy saint. He was no different now than when he was as Zahilla. Seeking power and glory for himself but proclaiming that it is for the good of the people. A man so selfish that he had used his wife as bait for his enemies. Rather than saving her, he called her a traitor and had her killed with his foes. Jack was certain that, as Arthur, he would do the same.

Still, such a quest would offer him the opportunities that he was looking for. The quest would take him far away from Guinevere. Such a journey would provide the perfect opportunity to distance himself from Guinevere and her growing affection. Perhaps, if he were fortunate, Arthur would meet with some "tragic accident" along the way. Then Jack could reclaim Fang and he could return to Lady Cailin victorious.

With as much sincerity as Jack could muster, he disagreed with Agravain and said, "That may be Sir Agravain. But if anyone can recover the Grail, it will be Arthur. He is a man chosen by God himself, blessed with divine providence. I have no doubt that he will succeed where others would surely fail."

Palamedes' eyes shone with admiration as Lancelot spoke. "Well said, my friend! Arthur is the true king, destined to lead us to glory. With Merlin's guidance, I have no doubt that the Grail will be found and restored to its rightful place in Camelot."

Agravain merely scoffed, his lip curling in disdain. "We shall see," he muttered, before turning on his heel and striding away.

As Agravain departed, Jack found himself wishing he could do the same. The charade of playing the loyal knight was growing increasingly wearisome, especially in the face of Palamedes' unshakable faith in Arthur. But he knew he had to maintain his composure, at least for a while longer. The Grail quest presented an opportunity, and he would not let it slip through his fingers.

The following day, Lancelot found himself once more in the practice yard, Balin at his side as they sparred. Their blades clashed, the familiar rhythm of steel on steel filling the air.

But as the duel wore on, Lancelot noticed a strange transformation in Balin's eyes. What were once warm brown irises now glowed an eerie emerald green, the whites swirling with a purple, opalescent mist, like clouds churning in a twilight sky. Lancelot's breath caught in his throat as he recognized that uncanny look - it was the same bewitching haze he had seen when Merlin's compulsions had briefly ensnared his own mind.

Balin's strikes took on a ferocious intensity, his enchanted eyes burning with murderous intent. Lancelot could feel the strain on his weapon, the telltale groans of metal under duress, as he desperately parried Balin's relentless onslaught.

Lancelot grunted as he deflected Balin's next deadly blow, the force of the attack sending vibrations up his arm. Realizing his friend meant to slay him, Lancelot had no choice but to respond in kind. He countered with a savage overhand strike aimed at Balin's head, putting all his weight behind the killing blow. But those hypnotic, mist-swirled eyes showed no hint of the friend he knew, promising only violence.

At the last moment, Lancelot's cursed blade shattered against Balin's, the metal shrieking as it fragmented. The shards scattered across the ground as Lancelot stared down at the fresh break in dismay.

Balin's brow furrowed with concern, his eyes flickering back to their natural hue as the compulsion's grip faltered. "Lancelot, forgive—" Balin began.

Lancelot waved him off. "It's good to be prepared to fight one's brothers in arms. You are lucky this sword broke before I could land a killing blow - every sword I wield meets the same fate once I mean to slay my opponent." His voice took on a rueful tone as he glanced down at the shattered blade. "Had it not broken, you would be dead by my hand."

Balin paled slightly at Lancelot's matter-of-fact admission. To have come so close to death at the hands of his friend was sobering. He knew then that he could never risk crossing blades with Lancelot again, lest that cursed inevitability finally catch up to him.

"You're right," Balin said slowly. "I would not wish to face you in true combat after witnessing the power you wield." He fell silent briefly, thinking, before a resolute look entered his eyes.

Slowly, Balin reached behind him and withdrew the gleaming Arondight, the ancestral blade of his family. He extended it hilt-first toward Lancelot. "Here, take my sword. Arondight has never failed those of my bloodline. If any blade could defy the curse that destroys all others you wield, it would be this one."

Lancelot eyed the legendary weapon skeptically. "Your trust in Arondight to deliver a killing stroke without breaking is folly. But the gesture is admirable." He shook his head. "Even so, she deserves to live on as your family's proud legacy, not be reduced to scraps in my grasp."

Balin shook his head adamantly. "Nay, Lancelot. I insist. If any man is worthy of wielding Arondight, it is you." His expression became almost wistful. "Besides, I am in need of a sword seeking a companion. Like you, Arondight seems to be happy alone."

Lancelot hesitated, his fingers itching to grip the familiar hilt. "You speak of glory, Balin. But oft times, the greatest glory is found in a single blade, rather than two."

Balin's eyes widened slightly at the implication, then a rueful smile tugged at his lips. "Then I suppose I shall have to prove myself worthy of that glory, hmm?" He held out Arondight, his

gaze steady. "Take her, Lancelot. Let us see if she can withstand the trials that have broken all the others."

With a resigned sigh, Lancelot accepted the sword, feeling the familiar weight and balance in his hand. "Very well, Balin. But know this - she is not mine. Arondight, like all the rest, shall eventually meet her end in my grasp."

With a resigned sigh, Lancelot accepted the sword, feeling Arondight's familiar weight and balance as he gave her an experimental swing. "Very well, Balin. But know this - no matter how steadfast her heritage, even this storied blade is not destined to be mine forever. Like all others that have gone before, she shall eventually meet her end by my hand."

As Lancelot turned to leave, his gaze lingered on Balin, the memory of the eerie emerald gleam and swirling purple mist that had overcome his friend's eyes burned into his mind. It was the same bewitching haze he had witnessed when Merlin's compulsions briefly enslaved his own tongue, forcing vile words he would have gladly "cut out" from their source.

A knot of unease formed in Lancelot's stomach. Balin's strange behavior could only have been Merlin's doing - an attack on his life, no doubt sanctioned by that snake Zahilla under the pretense of this foolish Grail quest. Lancelot could not shake the feeling that darker forces were uniting against them all under Zahilla's shadowed influence.

The Grail quest, with all its promises of glory and divine providence, seemed more like a ruse with each passing moment. What is Zahilla truly seeking? Lancelot mused, his grip tightening around Arondight's hilt. The so-called "King" Arthur had never been one to do what he claimed, his selfish nature and lust for power always lurking just beneath the surface.

No, there must be some hidden agenda that Zahilla believes will further his own designs. The idea of recovering a cup that some overzealous god drank from being the true object of Arthur's desires seemed overly simplistic to Lancelot. Whatever the Grail truly represented, he was certain it was not the holy sacrament Camelot's deluded knights believed.

Lancelot continued on, his mind racing. If there was one thing he knew about his adversary, it was that Zahilla was never quite what he appeared to be. And the presence of Merlin's trickery only confirmed Lancelot's doubts about the quest's true purpose. I must tread carefully, he thought, gaze fixed on the shimmering blade in his hand. Arondight may be the only thing standing between me and Zahilla's machinations...and Merlin's manipulations will be repaid in kind when the time comes. The following day, the courtyard of Camelot buzzed with excitement as word spread of Merlin's return and the prospect of a quest for the fabled Holy Grail. Lancelot's heart quickened at the very notion. Could this be the opportunity he had been awaiting—*a chance to escape the confines of Camelot and Guinevere's tempting presence?*

Away from the castle walls and the burden of his knightly vows, he could be Jack once more, the intrepid explorer beholden only to the odyssey that bound him to this realm. The thrill of adventure coursed through his veins, and he yearned to lose himself in the wilds, far from the trappings of court and the ever-watchful eyes of the king.

Anticipation drove his steps as Lancelot made his way to the great hall, where Arthur would surely announce the details of this sacred undertaking. As he neared the chamber, whispers reached his ears—murmurs of Merlin having divined the Grail's path, of a journey fraught with peril that would test even the truest knights.

As Lancelot steeled himself and entered the hall, his gaze was immediately drawn to Excalibur, resting proudly upon the round table, her golden hilt glinting in the torchlight. A pang of longing tugged at his heart—Fang, his true sword, rightfully belonged in his hand. But the ancient blade remained elusive, seemingly spirited away by Merlin's trickery.

"Lancelot!" A familiar voice called out, thick with barely contained excitement.

He turned to see Sir Gawain striding towards him, the knight's eyes alight with fervent zeal. Of all the Round Table's warriors, Gawain's devotion to Arthur and the ideals of Camelot burned brightest.

"Have you heard the whispers, my friend?" Gawain clapped a hand on Lancelot's shoulder, his grip almost painfully tight. "Merlin has returned! And they say he knows the path to the legendary Grail itself!"

Lancelot managed a thin smile, forcing levity into his tone despite his private misgivings.

"Indeed, the rumors are hard to ignore amidst such feverish anticipation." As he spoke, Jack had to wonder, so there is a quest!

"Can you imagine?" Gawain went on, his voice dropping to a conspiratorial murmur. "Us, the greatest knights who ever lived, embarking on a quest to recover Christendom's most sacred relic? Why, our names shall be forever etched into the annals of history!"

"You seem to have decided the outcome before the journey has even begun," Lancelot replied dryly. "Surely the path will not be as straight as Merlin's return might suggest."

Gawain waved a dismissive hand. "Naysayer! Have you so little faith in our prowess? In our king's divine mandate to lead us to glory?"

He dropped his voice further, leaning in with the air of sharing a great secret. "Word is Arthur plans to depart on the morrow, taking only his most trusted knights. You'll be among them, of course - who else could he rely upon more than his greatest champion?"

Before Lancelot could respond, the crowd began to hush, signaling Arthur's arrival. Gawain shot him a grin, straightening up with eagerness written across his features.

As Arthur emerged, flanked by the wizened sorcerer, a hush fell over the gathered crowd. Jack's gaze locked onto Merlin, his eyes narrowing as he studied the so-called wizard. *What game was the immortal playing at now?* Clearly, his fascination with Jack's suffering in this Odyssey ran deeper than mere idle interest.

A surge of anger coursed through Jack as he recalled Merlin's taunting words from their strange, frozen encounter. The insolent deity had spoken so casually of the unspeakable agonies Jack had

endured, as if a millennium spent in the Odyssey were a trifling matter, a mere nod to the torments of Jack's endless penance.

"It is true - our faithful Merlin has divined the path to the most sacred of relics, the Holy Grail itself!" Arthur proclaimed.

A murmur of awe rippled through the crowd, but Lancelot remained focused, his eyes now fixed on Merlin, the very same fiend who had trapped him the other day. Jack watched him closely, anger coursing through him as he recalled the deity's taunting words about the agonies Jack had endured. If this "excuse for a god" believed he could manipulate Jack's penance for his own amusement, he was sorely mistaken.

"However," Arthur continued, snapping Lancelot back to the quest ahead, "the road ahead is fraught with peril. Camelot cannot risk the kingdom's stability by departing with my full company of knights."

Lancelot's heart sank as Arthur's gaze found him amidst the assembled warriors.

"Sir Lancelot, my most trusted warrior, shall remain to rule in my stead alongside my queen, Guinevere. Her word shall be law, enforced by his blade if necessary."

The words landed like a kick to the gut, but Jack did not allow his fury to show outwardly. So be it - if Zahilla, the dragon king, insisted on keeping him leashed in Camelot while he chased this false Holy Grail, then Jack would bide his time accordingly.

As the crowd's cheers washed over him, a cruel smile played across Lancelot's lips. Merlin seemed to believe that pain and time were one and the same for their kind. But the arrogant deity was gravely mistaken - Jack would prove there was a vast difference between enduring agonies eternal and experiencing true, unending torment.

When Merlin and Zahilla returned from their self-important quest, Jack would ensure they understood that difference firsthand. Soon, Jack would make him and Zahilla intimately familiar with the kind of torment that transcended a mere millennium of pain. When next they met, the tormentor would become the tormented.

As Lancelot stepped away, his jaw set with grim determination, he thought, let them celebrate their grand delusion - a grail quest led by an arrogant false-king and his meddlesome wizard puppet-master. The reckoning would come, and when it did, Jack's vengeance would be as eternal as the suffering he meant to inflict.